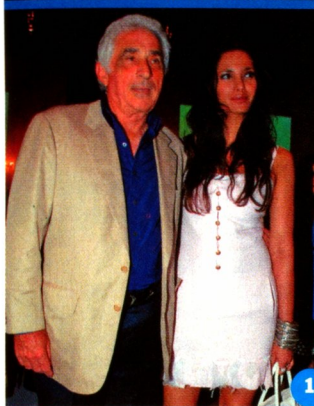


STAR WALK



2

1. SHOWSTOPPERS: Padma Lakshmi with boyfriend Ted Forstmann of IMG at Pria Kataria Puri's show

2. EYES RIGHT: (From left) Urmila Matondkar, Amisha Patel, Kajol, Shabina Khan, Kareena Kapoor and Saif

1

3. TWINKLE LITTLE STAR: Darsheel Safary walks the ramp for Neeta Lulla



Park Avenue
Corporate dressing got a fashionable 15 minutes on the ramp

Nandita Mahtani

Tie and dye shirts and kurtas set the tone for this line

collection. Paparazzi. Structured jackets in jute linen, with pin tucks on the arm started with a bang but became repetitive towards the end.

With the form fitting silhouette finding many takers, Khanna, who made Ranbir Kapoor strut his stuff, says, "I've been doing only menswear but the demand today has increased so much that I wish there were four of me." While this resurgence spells reassurance for Khanna, for others it's a sound business decision. That is why Mahtani, a women's wear designer, debuted her men's collection this season. And Kolkata designers Dev r Nil, who have dabbled in womanly vanities so far, are seriously considering a men's collection. "We've been making outfits for men as special orders and realise that there is a huge market for it," says Dev.

With a growing market, designers now also have more focused retail options like Mumbai stores Ayamik and Aza Men catering to the style conscious male. Aza Men showcases lines by Bal, Kumar, Wendell Rodericks and new kids on the block Halder, Manish Gupta and Singh. Alka Nishar, owner of Aza Men, says, "Earlier men bought designer wear only for weddings. But the customer today wants

to make a style statement even at a casual lunch". An upward curve in menswear may also mean an increase in the number of male models at LFW.

Menswear aside, the week was not without its winners. Mukherjee washed his dirty linen in public (with a laundry line strung across the ramp) and took his critics to the cleaners. Deep-sea divers met biker bling at his brightest collection, prompting fashion priestess Suzy Menkes of *International Herald Tribune* to break into a rare smile. While Mumbai boy Nachiket Barve's impeccable finishing had the critics sighing, Drashta Sarvaiya made a strong statement with her bold colours and Rimzim Dadu shone with woven and quilted dresses. The other show that prevented the week from becoming a long April Fool's Day was the new talent at the Gen Next show. Gupta's all-ivory collection with surface texturing was promising as was Neelanjana Ghosh's line of jersey dresses.

Even as the red carpet at the National Centre for Performing Arts is rolled up and international buyers and foreign media return perplexed to their prêt predilections, it's time the desi designer community took a closer look at its leanings. With the seasonal fashion focus getting fuzzier with every bi-annual showing—spring-summer showed up on the fall ramp—it is time to streamline the style-list and strengthen troops. After all, Mukherjee can't always save the day. ■